

MANDAR DEODHAR

prawled across two floors of Fortune Terraces, an edifice in suburban Mumbai once home to popular filmmaker Rohit Shetty's production company, is the office of The Viral Fever or TVF as the company is popularly known. Around 100 people work here, developing content for its four YouTube channels—The Viral Fever, Girliyapa, Screen Patti and The Timeliners—which cumulatively have 28.2 million subscribers, as well as long format originals for leading OTT platforms. . What binds Shetty and TVF together is they are market leaders in their respective fields. Shetty has an iron grip on the big screen with his action spectacles while TVF is a trusted entity for entertaining streaming content, be it sketches or series.

Two of the most beloved shows on OTT in 2022 came from TVF: season three of *Gullak* (SonyLIV) and season two of *Panchayat* (Amazon Prime Video). TVF's young workforce is relishing one of its most prolific and successful phases. Every platform now wants a TVF show. And when they don't, TVF puts it up on its own YouTube channel as it did with *Aspirants*, which has over 60 million views. That the core team of TVF is made up of IIT graduates, or as the company's founder Arunabh Kumar calls it, "failed engineers", makes its rise all the more impressive. "Now we are so popular that OTT platforms book in advance what is in development," says Kumar.

KEEPING IT SIMPLE AND REAL

So, why is everyone keen to work with TVF? In an OTT landscape cluttered with dark dramas or crime thrillers, TVF eschews violence and gore to remain faithful to its core audience of youth, delighting them with shows such as *Kota Factory*, *Hostel Daze*, *Girls Hostel*, *ImMature*, *The Interns*, *Cubicles*, to name a few. "We don't see them as confused, eccentric kids, but as people," says Raghav Subbu, director of *Kota Factory* and season one of *Hostel Daze*. "We tap into their aspirations." *Yeh Meri Family*, *Gullak* and *Panchayat* have further expanded TVF's following with their real and relatable depictions of the Indian middle class family. Palash Vaswani, director of season 2 amd 3 of *Gullak*, credits it to a simple philosophy: "What we see and know and believe in is what we make."

A decade now in the show business, TVF has given us a new range of actors (Sumeet Vyas, Gajraj Rao, Jitendra Kumar, Ahsaas Channa, Srishti Shrivastava, Sunny Hinduja), a talented bunch of writers (Chandra Kumar of *Panchayat* or Durgesh Singh of *Gullak*) and proved that engineers make for great directors (Deepak Kumar Mishra, Sameer Saxena, among others). "TVF's main focus is not the frills surrounding the core concept but the core concept itself," says actor Maanvi Gagroo, who rose to fame with TVF's *Triplings* and then bagged *Four More Shots Please!*.

Kumar and his cohort now are expanding their regional slate, rolling out fresh seasons of their popular properties like *Pitchers*, *Triplings* and *Girls Hostel* and finally kicking off with film production. Their mantra continues to be "Lights Action Experiment".

THE YOUNG AND THE INGENIOUS

For Kumar, an IIT Kharagpur graduate, the idea to set up TVF came from recognising a gaping void in India's entertainment programming. There was a dearth of shows, especially funny ones, for the youth and their perspective on television. "In my common room, no one was watching Indian TV shows. It was all [US sitcoms] *Seinfeld* and *Friends*," recalls Kumar. "Everyone wanted to see [Indian shows], but there was nothing out there. I thought maybe we are not telling their stories." Kumar figured he may as well take the leap. However, it would take him four years to get to that stage.

In the interim, he assisted Farah Khan on *Om Shanti Om*, an experi-